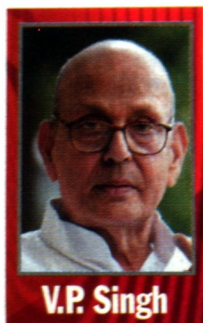


Parliament vs PM

The Government should observe democratic propriety and pay heed to the majority in Parliament



V.P. Singh

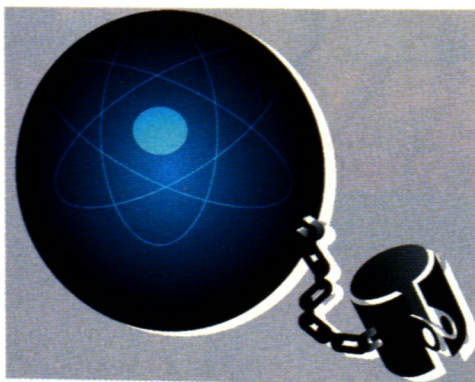
The issue of the Indo-US nuclear agreement is not confined only to nuclear energy but also to democratic propriety. Democracy does not survive on technicalities but on its spirit. The essence of parliamentary democracy lies in the fact that the legislature controls the executive. The day the executive disregards the legislature, democracy will be dead. How democratic is the stand of a prime minister who insists on a deal which is opposed by the majority of the parliamentarians?

In spite of all the tom-tomming about energy abundance through imported reactors, the Government has not told us as to what percentage of electricity will imported nuclear reactors give us? Knowledgeable sources say that the maximum contribution from imported nuclear plants will be around 5 per cent. With the same outlay of more than Rs 1,00,000 crore that we are going to make in imported nuclear plants, we can get more and cheaper electricity from our own resources. The price of electricity per unit from imported nuclear reactors, in larger part of India is, much more than as from coal fired, hydro or gas plants. The PM, in a letter written to me, has confirmed that up to 800 km from coal-pit head the cost of nuclear power does not compare favourably with that of thermal power. With India stepping in as a large buyer, uranium prices will go up, resulting in the cost of electricity rising manifold. Based on the prices at which various countries have imported nuclear reactors, the cost per megawatt of installed capacity of imported nuclear reactors is estimated to be two-three times higher than our coal-fired plants.

Moreover, our indigenous programmes, power plants and fast-breeder reactors, have started functioning. The next step is thorium-reactors which will open an infinite source of energy. We have the largest reserves of thorium in the world. This was the vision of Homi Bhabha and Jawahar Lal Nehru of energy independence based on our own resources. We need nuclear energy but not this deal. If somebody says that I will give milk it is welcome, but if he says I will give milk if you polish my boots, it becomes a different proposition. According to the Indo-US nuclear agreement: "Either party shall have the right to terminate this agreement prior to its expiration on one year's written notice to the other party." With this termination clause where is the much trumpeted energy security? Termination clause

can be invoked any time, whether we test a nuclear explosive device or not, even a foreign policy, not suited to the US, can trigger this termination. A nuclear-bomb test, against US wishes, will certainly invoke termination. Our security is severely compromised. We will need to test our new hydrogen-bombs sooner or later. Can we independently do so? Whatever flexibility we will have, will be under US's approving nod. On termination, we will have to return all nuclear and non-nuclear components and fuel that we have imported from the US. Every Government will be very wary of annoying the US because of the unbearable losses that shall befall us on its termination. Further, according to the agreement, reprocessing can be suspended by the US in "exceptional circumstances". These have not been defined. Whenever the US raises its brows, it can become exceptional circumstances. The core nuclear technologies of enrichment reprocessing and heavy water have not been given. We have not been recognised as a "nuclear weapon state."

The nuclear agreement is subject to national laws. The



SAURABH SINGH

Hyde Act, a national law of the US, states among other things that the US Government must at the earliest achieve a moratorium on the production of fissile material for explosive purposes by India apart from restricting its weapons programme. There can be no rebuttal of the fact that the Hyde Act will apply to the US President. He will have to act if we, in their mind, infringe the Hyde Act. Termination, return, suspension all will follow. The only right we have secured in such an event is of consultations. The decisions are all with the US. We will be coerced into serving US strategic interests. Their diktat regarding our vote on Iran and our abandoning the Indo-Iran pipeline project is a pre-taste. Is this not polishing the boots of the US? We will be sucked into supporting the US military adventures in the Middle-East and reap the hostility of the victims of US actions. I am in favour of Indo-US friendship. It is in our interest. Let us have a healthy friendship with the US, but not one of bondages. The UPA Government should pay heed to the majority in the Parliament and thereby save democracy, as well as itself, rather than, murder democracy and commit suicide. However, sense now seems to have prevailed with Dr Manmohan Singh making a wise statement that his Government doesn't have a single point agenda and will run its full term. The present impasse with the Left appears diffused. But the confrontation with the majority of Parliament and the PM needs to be sorted out judiciously.

(The author is a former prime minister of India)